

The Plane Truth

CHINA
ARUNACHAL PRADESH

An American adventurer tracks down the remains of several US Air Force aircraft that crashed nearly 60 years ago in the jungles of Arunachal Pradesh

Assam



KUHLES WITH ONE OF HIS FINDS IN THE DEEP JUNGLES

By Sandeep Unnithan

For nearly 60 years, the wreckage of close to 400 US transport aircraft lay undisturbed in the remote jungles of north-eastern India. These are the aircraft that didn't survive the air bridge maintained by the US Air Force during World War II, linking British India to China over the Himalayas. Back in the United States, thousands of relatives resigned themselves to the 'Missing in Action' tag which their government gave the young aircrews. Until the arrival of intrepid explorer, self-confessed adventure nut and history junkie Clayton Kuhles, that is.

In five expeditions in as many years, this 52-year-old businessman from Arizona has legged his way through the leech-infested jungles of Arunachal Pradesh to rediscover the remains of 15 crashed US Air Force aircraft, bringing closure to dozens of families. Kuhles taps into his contacts in the hill tribes of the north-eastern state for sightings of crash remains. He spends a month and about \$8,000 every year to excavate the remains of the transport aircraft which went down due to bad weather or engine trouble. In just six weeks between September

and October this year, he discovered the remains of seven crashed aircraft. He combs through the aircraft remains like a police investigator looking for clues to aircraft registration; an engine number, anything that could help identify what the elements haven't erased in over a half-century. After his return, Kuhles makes it a point to personally look up the relatives of the crashed crew—each aircraft carried over six personnel—giving them any personal effects he finds at the crash site.

There are few dry eyes on such occasions. His tireless enthusiasm leaves even the vast machinery of the US government, which is supposed to be doing what Kuhles is doing, out of breath. US teams landed in Arunachal Pradesh last month, nearly five years after he reported his findings. In fact, it was his missions which roused the lethargic US military bureaucracy into action. "It gives me a feeling of accomplishment to bring closure to the thousands of family members who care and are not getting answers about their next of kin from the US government," says Kuhles. Clearly his is a mission that is far from being accomplished. But he's getting there. ■